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start here

Show Off Mode

9 days · 1 hour a day · by the end you won't be revising — you'll be showing off

This is the front door to your **Phase 1 skills build** for the Data Technician Level 3 End Point Assessment. Nine workpacks. One per day. Each one teaches a small named device you'll be using — and explaining — by the time you sit AM1.

Every chapter follows the same shape: a brief, a named strategy, a timed task on the StreamWave data, a *Say It Out Loud* section (the bit that actually wins the distinction), a fun bit, and a done-when checklist. Open file 01 to start. From then on, the only decision each day is "open the next number".

The **Gold Rule** sits behind everything: *minimise anxiety, maximise the ability to show off*. The technical work is teachable. The confidence to narrate it is what assessors grade hardest. Both are in this pack.

Just nine days. Is that really enough?

— you, sceptical on Day 0

Nine hours of focused work, named devices, a real dataset. Yes.

and a clear path through.



BRAIN POWER

What's the *one thing* about the EPA that worries you most? Note it down. This pack is built to answer it.

turn over — the Gold Rule →

The Gold Rule

| *Minimise anxiety. Maximise the ability to show off.*

What this actually means

Two technicians can sit the same assessment with the same skills and walk out with different grades. The variable is not Excel knowledge — it's **the ability to talk about the work confidently**. The Pass-grade candidate completes the task. The Distinction-grade candidate completes the task *and tells you why each click happened*.

This pack is built around that observation. Every chapter has a *Say It Out Loud* section that practises the narration. Every named device — the Cleaning Sequence, the Polish Pyramid, the Three Questions Before You Delete — is something you can say out loud to an assessor and have them tick a box.

What "showing off" doesn't mean

It doesn't mean being arrogant, or talking endlessly, or memorising scripts. It means: **narrating your reasoning** as you work. Out loud. Calmly. Once a day for nine days. By Day 10 it's automatic.

SHOW THIS OFF

Every chapter from here on has a green **SHOW THIS OFF** badge like this one. When you see it, that's a moment the assessor is actively looking for. Practise the wording out loud — not the technical action underneath, the *sentence*. The sentence is what gets graded; the click is just the proof.

ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

The most common reason capable candidates fail to hit Distinction isn't a technical gap — it's *silence* during a demo. Assessors can only grade what they can hear. Saying the next thing you're about to click, before you click it, is the cheapest grade-uplift in the whole programme.

What "showing off" sounds like

Same task. Same clicks. One candidate stays silent; the other narrates. The first scores Pass; the second scores Distinction. The clicks are identical — only the running commentary changes.

Instead of silence...	Try saying out loud...
<i>(clicks Get Data, picks the file, clicks Connection Only)</i>	"I'm loading all five files as Connection Only so the pipeline stays auditable and refresh-safe."
<i>(scrolls through subscriber_id column, spots an oddity)</i>	"Row 47 has a different format — that would break the merge silently if I didn't catch it now."
<i>(right-clicks Remove Duplicates)</i>	"Group By first confirmed these were migration duplicates — so removing them is justified, not reflex."
<i>(builds a PivotTable)</i>	"Region in Rows, plan_type in Columns, count of record_id in Values — answers the cross-tab question without ten nested SUMIFs."
<i>(presses Refresh)</i>	"One click and the whole pipeline reruns — that's why the upstream work matters."

By Day 9, sentences like these will be muscle memory. Practise one per day in the *Say It Out Loud* section of each chapter.



RED FLAG • HEADS-UP BEFORE DAY 1

If you're working on a Mac, Excel for Mac's Power Query is missing some features the Windows version has — most importantly, *From PDF*. Day 1 includes a PDF file (the viewer survey) and Day 6 uses some PivotChart features that behave differently on Mac. Workarounds are flagged inside each chapter when they're needed.

If you're using Excel for the Web, Power Query is read-only — you can refresh queries but you can't author them. For this programme you need *Excel for Windows desktop* or a workaround setup explained on Day 1.

Meet StreamWave

A UK-based subscription streaming service. About 280 subscribers in the dataset (a sample). Manager: **Priya**. Problem: subscribers are cancelling at a higher rate than expected, and the senior team thinks the cause is price. Your job is to find out whether they're right.

THE BRIEF

Subscribers are cancelling more than expected.

Is the problem price?

— find out.

Priya:

"Welcome aboard.
Five files. A churn
problem. Insight by
Friday, please."

StreamWave

UK · subscription streaming

- ~280 subscribers in the dataset
- 5 data files + 2 year-on-year FY files
- 1 manager (Priya) wanting answers
- 1 exec meeting the following week

spoiler: it's not (just) price



Your data files

The whole pack uses one realistic dataset. Get to know it – every chapter builds on these files.



CSV

sw_subscribers.csv – *the backbone*

One row per subscriber: ID, name, region, plan_type, join_date, status. Everything else joins back to this.



CSV

sw_content_library.csv – *what's on the platform*

Every title: genre, content_type, release_year, age rating, average user rating.



XLSX

sw_viewing_activity.xlsx – *the big fact table*

~3,400 session records: which subscriber watched which title, when, for how long, on which device.



XLSX

sw_cancellations.xlsx – *who left, when, why*

Cancellation records. Includes the migration-flagged duplicates you'll meet on Day 2 – and use to learn the Delete Anomaly.



PDF

sw_viewer_survey.pdf – *the rebel*

Exit survey: satisfaction ratings (1–5), reason codes, free-text comments. Subscriber IDs in a third different format.

Plus on Day 3 – [sw_viewing_activity_FY2025_26.xlsx](#) and [sw_viewing_activity_FY2026_27.xlsx](#) arrive for the year-on-year append exercise.

How each day works

Every workpack from Day 1 onwards follows the same six-part structure. Learn it once, follow it nine times.
Total time per day: about 60 minutes.

Section	Time	What it is
The Brief	2 min	One paragraph: what today's about and why it matters.
Today's Strategy	read once	The named device — the Cleaning Sequence, the Polish Pyramid, etc.
The Task	30–40 min	Step-by-step instructions using the StreamWave data. Click by click.
Say It Out Loud	10 min	Prompts you answer aloud, as if the assessor is in the room. This is where distinction is built.
The Fun Bit	5 min	A puzzle, reveal or quick recap that locks the day in.
Done When	checklist	Three or four things that must be true before you move on.

If you run over on the Task, cut the Fun Bit. **Never cut Say It Out Loud** — that's where the grade lives.

Your 9-day skills build

Files are numbered 01–09. Open the next number. That's the only decision each day.

Day	Theme	Named device
01	Getting Data In	The Power Query Pipeline
02	Cleaning with Confidence	The Cleaning Sequence · Three Questions Before You Delete
03	The Merge	Append vs Merge · The Six Joins
04	Reading the Data	The Descriptive Five · Validate then Verify · The Two-Route Check
05	Patterns & Relationships	The Three Numbers of a Relationship
06	Pivots and Charts	The Chart Test · Refresh
07	Dashboard Polish	The Polish Pyramid
08	Effective Working Practices	Three Audiences, Three Voices · Headline → Evidence → Caveat
09	Handling the Questioning (AM1)	Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check

After Day 9: the AM1 mock demo days, then the AM2 (Professional Discussion) workpacks. *Phase 1 is what's in this pack.*

The assessment at a glance

Two methods, two grades, one overall result

- **AM1 – Scenario Demos with Questioning.** Two 45-minute practicals. After each, around 10 questions from the assessor. *Days 1–9 of this pack prepare you for AM1.*
- **AM2 – Professional Discussion + Portfolio.** One 60-minute structured discussion across four knowledge areas, anchored on your portfolio of evidence. *Separate workpacks later in the programme.*

How the grades combine

AM1	AM2	Overall
Pass	Pass	Pass
Distinction	Pass	Merit
Pass	Distinction	Merit
Distinction	Distinction	DISTINCTION

REMINDER

For a Distinction overall, you need Distinction on **both** components. A Distinction in AM1 (this pack) with a Pass in AM2 caps you at Merit. The work in this pack gets you to Distinction-ready for AM1; the AM2 workpacks do the same for the Professional Discussion.

Ready to go?

Before you open file 01, run this quick self-check.

- ☐ I've read the Gold Rule — and accept that narrating my work out loud is non-negotiable.
- ☐ I know what StreamWave is and what Priya wants by Friday.
- ☐ I know the names of the five data files I'll be working with from Day 1.
- ☐ I know each day follows the same six-part structure — Brief, Strategy, Task, Say It Out Loud, Fun Bit, Done When.
- ☐ I know there are nine named devices ahead, one per day, each one something I'll be able to recite by the end.
- ☐ I'm not going to cut *Say It Out Loud*, ever, even if I'm short on time.

DAY 1 — GETTING DATA IN

Open `Day01_Getting_Data_In.html`. Five files, three formats, one Power Query pipeline. The job today isn't to clean it, fix it, or analyse it — it's just to *get it in*, in a way that won't blow up later. **The Power Query Pipeline** is the named device. The journey starts there.

open file 01 — that's the only decision today.